

Claude Code in Public Administration: Pragmatic, Privacy-Compliant, Productive

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Chatbot vs. Coding Assistant

Chatbot (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.)

- Conversation-based, question-answer format
- Text-only interaction in the chat window
- No access to file system or terminal
- (Mostly) no independent execution of

Conversation partner for quick answers

Coding Assistant (Claude Code, Codex, etc.)

- Agentic: acts independently instead of just responding
- Reads/writes files directly in the project
- Runs terminal commands, tests, Git operations
- Works iteratively: Plan → Execute → Review → Correct
- Understands the context of entire codebases, not just code snippets

Active agent within your own project

The problem: data privacy and AI in public administration seem incompatible

- Locally installed tools such as Copilot, Cursor, Codex, or Claude Code usually cannot be used in a privacy-compliant way
- Use is usually only possible on special devices that are not connected to the administrative unit's official network

Claude Code on the web (claude.ai/code) combined with GitHub offers a pragmatic, privacy-compliant solution

The problem: data privacy and AI in public administration seem incompatible

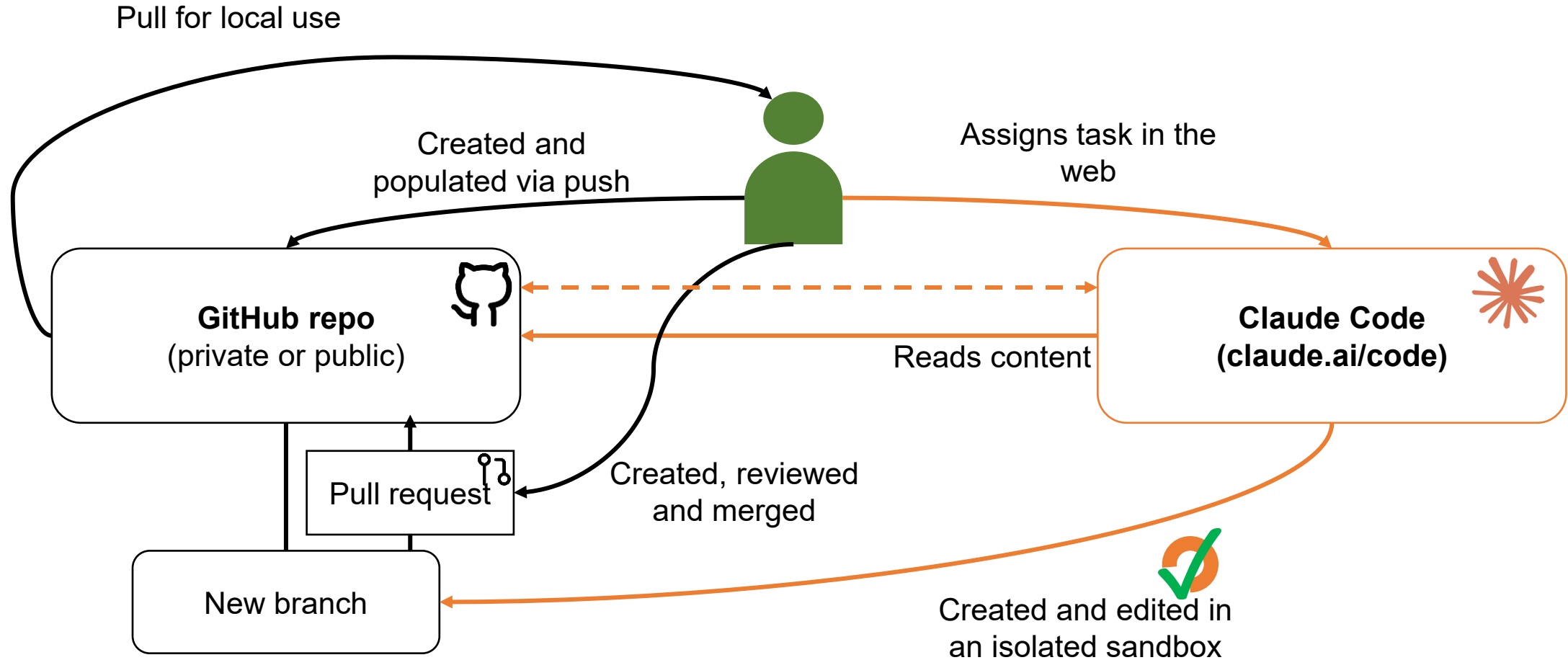
Anyone already using Claude Desktop or the CLI tool in a privacy-compliant way should stick with it and not switch to the web version

Use requires a paid plan and a GitHub account

- ✓ Paid Claude plan (at least Pro)
- ✓ GitHub account on the public github.com
- ✓ Access rights to GitHub repositories for Claude Code

Can be used immediately at a cost of approx. 20 francs per month

How Claude Code works



Where to use Claude Code ...and where less so



- Prototyping (dashboards, pipelines, reports)
- (extensive) documentation
- Time-consuming fixes
- Understanding larger codebases
- «*Whenever knowledge needs to be transferred from A to B*»



- Small fixes
- Working out precise visual corporate design specifications
- Generating ideas

5 tips for saving tokens



Renew session

- One task = one session.
- Too much context makes answers worse and more expensive



Claude.md

- short Claude.md
- general requirements for the tech stack as well as «Dos and Don'ts»



Prompts

- Be precise
- Give exact file paths and line numbers

✓ Sonnet 5
Opus 5
Haiku 5

Model

- Right model for the respective task
- Don't switch model within the session



Plan mode

- Enables a precise plan
- Editable
- Saves tokens in the long run

Example: dashboard workflow



Starting point

- Repo with an “empty” skeleton (CSS, folder structure) for a dashboard in Thurgau style.
- dbplyr code for retrieving data from the database in a views.R file
- Claude.md indicating the techstack and noting that the database is not reachable, but the structure can be derived from the views



Prompt (example)

«Fill the dashboard skeleton with sample data and working logic. Context: - Read CLAUDE.md for the tech stack and notes on the database - Read views.R to understand the structure of the views (columns, types, granularity) - The database is not reachable. Use the views Build the dashboard with 2-3 meaningful visualizations (time series, comparison by municipality/category) - Filters/inputs matching the dimensions of the views - KPI boxes at the top. Use existing CSS classes/folder structure, don't invent a new structure. Comment clearly and briefly.»



Result

- Functional dashboard that can be further developed (usually also with Claude Code)

claudecoder: an R package for the right setup

Sets up the repo



Depending on the template, the corresponding Claude.md is included



```
library(claudecoder)

create_ccr_repo(
  name       = "my_analysis",
  directory  = "~/projects",
  template   = "normal",      # or "dashboard", "package"
  github_organisation = NULL,  # NULL = your own account
  private    = TRUE
)
```

Defines .gitignore so that the real data is only available locally



anonym_dir() additionally enables anonymization of the data



Thank you!



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